Mujahideen commanders,' particularly Dostum.[17] The MEA's annual report 1992–93, not surprisingly, mentions nothing about this period and focuses only on relations after September 1992, by when India had begun consolidating relations with the *Jamiat-e-Islami* and Dostum's *Jumbish-e-Milli*.

## *Afghanistan's 'Che Guevara'*

The second aspect of India's relations with the UF was that they were personality-driven. New Delhi associated most with Massoud and his second-tier leadership and to a limited extent with Dostum, while others like Ismael Khan, Mohaqiq, and Karim Khalili were to be engaged with because they had influence on the ground.[18] The UF was a tactical alliance, or confederation, between warlords (or commanders) of different militias across Afghanistan who had differences among themselves but accepted Massoud's mediation. India's own links with these leaders were tactical, and based on their fallout with Pakistan. According to Sood, the R&AW developed links with the Hazaras and the Tajiks with ease, while Dostum remained 'dicey, but was to be kept.'[19] However, former Pakistani envoy to the Taliban regime, Iftikhar Murshed, claims that 'while India had, in the past, gone out of its way to advertise its good relations with the Rabbani regime, it was significant that New Delhi should have disclosed (through planted stories in the media) that it had also "established direct contact with General Dostum"'.[20] The *Times of India* indeed wrote such stories. Links with anti-Taliban factions were facilitated via New Delhi and Tajikistan (as well as other places), but India did not actively send its intelligence personnel to Afghanistan.[21]

The Afghan official responsible for facilitating the link with New Delhi throughout 1996–2001 (and then from 2001–07) was *Jamiat's* Massoud Khalili, allegedly 'the right–hand person of Massoud'.[22] Alumnus of the University of Delhi, Khalili had a good grasp of Indian politics and sensibilities. On 17 October 1996, soon after Kabul's fall to the Taliban, Khalili correctly assessed that 'the fall of Kabul came as a surprise to India. It was a new situation and they took time to reassess their position ... India should raise its voice when it sees Afghanistan's neighbour, in this case Pakistan, interfering in our domestic affairs'.[23] As former Indian ambassador to Iran and current vice president, M.